

Document	HR-01 Employee Handbook
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Employee Handbook

1. About this handbook

This handbook explains the day-to-day rules of working at Tallowby Freight Ltd. It covers everyone who works at our Leeds, Doncaster and Hull depots and in the head office at Leeds. It does not replace your contract of employment. Where the two say different things, your contract takes priority.

1.1 Who this applies to

The handbook applies to all employees, whether full-time, part-time or on a fixed-term contract. Agency workers should follow the sections on conduct, sickness reporting and health and safety, and should speak to their agency about anything to do with pay or holiday.

1.2 How it fits with other policies

Some topics have their own policy and are only summarised here. In particular:

- drivers' hours, vehicle checks and fines are covered by OPS-02 Vehicle & Driver Safety Standard;
- claiming back money you spend on company business is covered by FIN-03 Travel & Expenses Policy;
- working from home is covered by HR-05 Remote & Hybrid Work Policy;
- accidents and near misses are covered by HSE-04 Incident & Accident Reporting Procedure.

If you are unsure which policy applies, ask your line manager or email hr@tallowby.example.

2. Working hours

2.1 Office staff

The standard working week for office staff is 37.5 hours, Monday to Friday. Normal hours are 08:30 to 17:00 with an unpaid lunch break of 30 minutes. Office staff may use flexible start and finish times, provided they are at work during the core hours of 10:00 to 16:00 and their team's phones are covered from 08:30 to 17:00.

2.2 Depot and warehouse shifts

Warehouse and depot teams work to a shift rota. Rotas are published on the staff noticeboard and in StaffPoint (our HR system) at least 14 days in advance. Shift swaps must be agreed in advance by the Shift Manager.

2.3 Drivers

Drivers' working patterns are set by the Transport Planning Office and must stay within the legal limits on driving time and rest. These limits, and the company's own rules on top of them, are set out in OPS-02. Nothing in this handbook allows a driver to work beyond those limits.

2.4 Overtime

Overtime must be agreed with your line manager before you work it. Time worked without prior agreement will not normally be counted as overtime. How overtime is paid or given back as time off is set out in your contract.

3. Probation

3.1 Length of probation

All new starters, including internal transfers into a different job family, serve a probationary period of 6 months. Your line manager may extend it once, by up to 3 months, if more time is needed to reach a fair decision. You will be told in writing before the original period ends if it is being extended, and why.

3.2 Reviews and notice during probation

Your manager will hold short review meetings with you at the end of your first, third and fifth months. The aim is simple: to tell you honestly how you are getting on, and to sort out any problems early.

While you are on probation, either side can end the employment by giving 1 week's notice. Once you have passed probation, the notice periods in your contract apply.

4. Holidays

4.1 How much holiday you get

Full-time employees receive 25 days' paid holiday each year plus the 8 usual bank holidays in England. After 3 years' continuous service you receive one extra day, and after 5 years' service a second extra day, to a maximum of 27 days plus bank holidays. Part-time staff receive the same entitlement worked out in proportion to their contracted hours.

4.2 The holiday year and carrying days over

The holiday year runs from 1 January to 31 December. You can carry up to 5 unused days into the next year, but those days must be taken by 31 March or they will be lost.

4.3 Booking holiday

Request holiday through StaffPoint. As a rule, give at least twice as much notice as the length of the holiday you want: for example, two weeks' notice for one week off. Requests are approved in the order they are received. Holiday is not confirmed until your manager has approved it in StaffPoint, so please do not book travel before then.

4.4 Busy periods and bank holidays

Between 1 November and 24 December warehouse and transport staff may book no more than 5 days' holiday, because this is our busiest time of year. Depot staff may be rostered to work on bank

holidays. If you work a bank holiday, you will be given a day off in lieu, which must be taken within 8 weeks.

5. Sickness absence

5.1 Reporting that you are ill and keeping in touch

If you cannot come to work because you are ill, you must phone in yourself. Text messages, emails and messages passed on by friends or family are not accepted unless you are too ill to call.

- **Office, warehouse and workshop staff:** phone your line manager at least 1 hour before your shift starts, or by 09:30 at the latest if you work office hours.
- **Drivers:** phone the Transport Planning Office on ext. 100 (staffed 24 hours) at least 2 hours before your booked start time, so the load can be reallocated.

Tell us what is wrong, how long you expect to be off and whether any urgent work needs covering.

For the first 3 days of absence please call your manager each day before the same deadline. After that, agree with your manager how often you will be in touch.

5.2 Self-certification and fit notes

For absences of up to 7 calendar days you can certify yourself. Complete form HR-SC1 in StaffPoint within 2 working days of coming back. If you are off for more than 7 calendar days, you need a fit note from a doctor covering the time from day 8 onwards. Send a photo or scan of it to hr@tallowby.example as soon as you have it and bring in the original on your return.

5.3 Returning to work

After every absence, however short, your manager will hold a brief return-to-work meeting with you within 3 working days of your return. Drivers who have been off for more than 5 days, or who have started new medication, must also tell the Fleet Safety Manager before their first shift back.

5.4 Frequent or long absence

We will arrange a supportive review meeting if you have 3 separate absences, or 8 days of absence in total, in any rolling 12 months. After 4 weeks of continuous absence we will normally ask for your permission to refer you to occupational health. Details of company sick pay are in your contract of employment.

6. Conduct at work

6.1 Standards we expect

We expect everyone to treat colleagues, customers and members of the public with respect, to be honest in all their dealings and to follow safety rules without shortcuts. Bullying, harassment or discrimination will be treated as a disciplinary matter.

6.2 Gifts and hospitality

You may accept small gifts from customers or suppliers worth up to £50, such as a bottle of wine at Christmas. Anything worth more must be declared to your line manager and recorded in the gifts register before you accept it. You must never accept cash, vouchers or anything offered in return for winning or keeping business.

6.3 Smoking and vaping

Smoking and vaping are allowed only in the marked shelters at each depot. They are never allowed inside buildings, in the warehouse, on the loading bays or in any company vehicle, including when you are parked up on a break.

7. Disciplinary and grievance procedure

7.1 Informal and formal stages

Most minor problems are best dealt with by a quiet word from your manager. Informal discussions are noted in StaffPoint but are not formal warnings.

If informal action does not work, or the issue is more serious, the formal stages are:

- first written warning, which stays on your record for 6 months;
- final written warning, which stays on your record for 12 months;
- dismissal.

Before any formal decision there will be an investigation and a hearing. You will receive at least 2 working days' written notice of a hearing, together with copies of the evidence. You have the right to be accompanied at any formal disciplinary or grievance hearing by a work colleague or a trade union representative of your choice.

7.2 Gross misconduct

Some acts are serious enough to justify dismissal without notice, even for a first offence. Examples include theft, violence, working under the influence of alcohol or drugs, falsifying tachograph or delivery records, refusing a drug and alcohol test and deliberately ignoring safety rules.

7.3 Appeals

If you disagree with a formal decision, you can appeal in writing to the Head of People within 5 working days of receiving the outcome letter. The appeal will be heard by a manager who was not involved in the original decision.

7.4 Raising a grievance

If you have a problem at work, raise it with your line manager first. If that does not resolve it, or the problem is with your manager, put it in writing to HR at hr@tallowby.example. HR will arrange a meeting, normally within 10 working days.

8. Useful contacts

If you are not sure who to ask, start with HR.

- HR Advisor: ext. 214, hr@tallowby.example
- Transport Planning Office (24 hours): ext. 100
- IT Service Desk: ext. 300
- Health, Safety & Environment Manager: ext. 250